

FANTASTIC FOUR

Superheroic planet protectors

FANTASTIC FOUR

FACTFILE

CURRENT MEMBERS

MR. FANTASTIC (Reed Richards) Scientific genius; elastic powers.

INVISIBLE WOMAN (Susan Richards) Can turn her body or any other object invisible; projects invisible force fields.

THE THING (Ben Grimm)

Man monster with superhuman strength.

HUMAN TORCH (Johnny Storm) Generates fiery plasma over his entire body and can fly.

ADDITIONAL MEMBERS

CRYSTAL, **MEDUSA**,

SHE-HULK, **ANT-MAN** (Scott

Lang), **LUKE CAGE** (Carl

Lucas), **SHARON VENTURE**

(Ms. Marvel/She-Thing),

NAMORITA (Namorita

Prentiss)

BASE

The Baxter Building, NYC

FIRST APPEARANCE

Fantastic Four #1

(November 1961)

ALLIES/FOES

ALLIES Spider-Man, Namor, The

Sub-Mariner, Alicia Masters, Agatha

Harkness, Wyatt Wingfoot, Silver

Surfer, Lyja (Lyja Storm).

FOES Dr. Doom, Puppet Master,

Red Ghost and his Super-Apes,

Frightful Four, Galactus.



The Baxter Building was built by Noah Baxter, one of Reed's professors and mentor.

COSMIC RAYS

When the government threatened to withdraw its funding, Richards decided to take his prototype ship on a test flight with Grimm at the helm. Richards' fiancée Susan Storm and her teenage brother Johnny came along for the ride. Soon after takeoff, a solar flare bombarded the ship with an unknown form of cosmic radiation that mutated their bodies and gave them fantastic powers. Richards became MR. FANTASTIC, Susan Storm became INVISIBLE WOMAN, Ben Grimm became THE THING, and Johnny Storm became the HUMAN TORCH.

NO CHARGE

Pledging to use their new powers for the good of mankind, the four adventurers formed a legal corporation. The Fantastic Four safeguards the planet from human and extraterrestrial supermenaces, and also specializes in pure scientific research and explorations into the unknown. Funded by the patents on inventions and scientific discoveries made by Richards, the team offers its services without charge.

On their first public mission, the Fantastic Four prevented the MOLE MAN conquering the world. They later stopped the SKRULLS invading Earth and the MIRACLE MAN from blackmailing New York City. They were also responsible for the return of Prince NAMOR, the Sub-Mariner: the Human Torch found him living like a tramp in the Bowery slums and helped restore his lost

Reed Richards was a scientific genius who dreamed of exploring the stars. His roommate at New York's State University was football star Ben Grimm. Reed shared his dream of building a starship and Grimm, who wanted to become a pilot, promised to fly it. Grimm subsequently joined the US Air Force and became a test pilot and astronaut. Meanwhile, using his own family's fortune as well as money from the government, Richards built a starship.



IF YOU WANT TO FLY TO THE STARS, THEN YOU PILOT THE SHIP! COUNT ME OUT!

YOU KNOW WE HAVEN'T DONE ENOUGH RESEARCH INTO THE EFFECT OF COSMIC RAYS! THEY MIGHT KILL US ALL OUT IN SPACE!

Fearing that Reed's ship didn't have sufficient shields, Ben tried to talk the others out of flying.



I AIN'T BEN ANymore... I'M WHAT SUSAN CALLED ME... THE THING!!

AND I'LL CALL MYSELF... MISTER FANTASTIC!!

The Fantastic Four have vowed to safeguard Earth.

ALTERNATE WORLDS

After a prolonged engagement, Reed Richards married Susan Storm and she gave birth to their son Franklin. Soon afterward, Richards' scientist father Nathaniel switched young Franklin with his alternate-world teenage counterpart in an effort to help the team battle Hyperstorm, a menace they were destined to face in the future. Richards and Doctor Doom were later transported into a possible alternate future where the son of Franklin had conquered the universe.

A few months later, Franklin somehow created a pocket universe called Counter Earth, where he transported his

THE FANTASTIC FOUR

1 The Thing 2 Mr. Fantastic

3 Invisible Girl 4 Human Torch



BASES AND EQUIPMENT

The team established its first headquarters on the top five floors of the Baxter Building in Manhattan, New York City. Although this building was later destroyed, Richards designed another base that was constructed in outer space by his former mentor Noah Baxter. The new Baxter Building is equipped with a state-of-the-art security system that is regularly upgraded. Roberta, the Fantastic Four's robot receptionist, is networked with the team's main computer and can undertake hundreds of tasks simultaneously.

Richards has also designed many different types of Fantasti-cars for easy travel around Manhattan (they're easy to park). Each team member is equipped with a wireless communications link, and an emergency flare gun. The FF also have a Pogo-Plane that is outfitted with vertical take off and landing capabilities, a captured Skrull starship that they use for galactic travel and a time platform and space/time sled that allow them to visit alternate time eras or dimensions. The team's costumes are composed of unstable molecules that are specifically designed to adjust to their individual powers.



Roberta is able to operate 24 hours a day and can answer various calls simultaneously.

ESSENTIAL STORYLINES

- **Greatest Villains of the Fantastic Four (tpb)** The FF battle Psycho-Man, Blastaar, Annihilus, Puppet Master, the Mad Thinker, and Doctor Doom.
- **Fantastic Four: Monsters Unleashed (tpb)** The Hulk, Ghost Rider, Wolverine and Spider-Man help the FF battle the Mole Man and the Skrulls.
- **Fantastic Four: Nobody Gets Out Alive (tpb)** The FF travel through time and various alternate dimensions on a hunt for the missing and presumed dead Reed Richards.
- **Fantastic Four: Unthinkable (tpb)** Dr. Doom attempts to use black magic as well as Reed and Sue's own children as weapons against the FF.
- **Fantastic Four: Authoritative Action (tpb)** To the world's horror and outrage, the FF seize control of Latveria after Doom is apparently destroyed.

parents to protect them from a psychic monster called ONSLAUGHT. The FF later returned and soon faced another reality-altering cosmic entity called Abraxas. Shortly after they defeated him, the Invisible Woman gave birth to a daughter, named Valeria.

CHANGING THE WORLD

The Fantastic Four have been embroiled in every major event on Earth over the past several years. Reed supported the Superhuman Registration Act, although he lost the backing of every other member of the team. When the Civil War (see pp. 84-5) ended, he and Sue reunited and left the team for a while to re-examine their marriage. During the Secret Invasion (see pp. 326-7) the Skrulls captured Reed and Sue and sent the others, including Franklin and Valeria, into the Negative Zone. They all survived and were reunited, but the experience inspired Reed to start exploring alternate universes.

TD, MF



The team have traveled into space and alternate dimensions.



ISSUE #1

After being exposed to cosmic rays, the Fantastic Four kept a low profile and didn't reveal their powers to the public until giant monsters began attacking atomic research facilities.